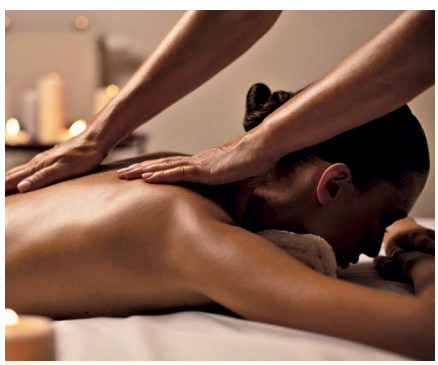
THE CONSEQUENCES OF COLOURISM

Little wonder, entire generations of young children grow up believing they are not good enough because of the colour of their skin, buying into the narrative whole-heartedly. Everywhere they look—on cinema screens, covers of magazines, advertisements—they have fair faces staring back at them. Hema Malini, Shabana Azmi, Rekha or Smita Patil were the exceptions, not the rule. The Hindi film hero serenaded the fair maiden with songs that went '*Yeh kaali kaali aankhein, yeh gore gore gaal*' (these black eyes, fair cheeks) or '*Gore gore mukhde pe kala kala chashma*' (dark glasses on a fair face). If there was any consolation, it was in the words '*Hum kaale hain toh kya hua, dilwale hain*' (so what if we are dark, we are big of heart). It was in the world of ramp modelling that dusky beauty found



↘ BODY POLISHING

Certain products promise lighter skin by scrubbing out deep-seated grime and dirt from the skin pores

Cost: Rs 900 upwards

↘ CREAMS

Common ingredients in bleaching creams include hydroquinone, kojic acid and certain corticosteroids. These work to suppress the production of melanin in the skin

Cost: Varies

Photographs; Shutterstock



MANDAR DEODHAR

CASE STUDY

SNIGDHA NAIR | 25 | *Assistant film director*

"WHEN KICKED OUT OF DANCE GROUP, I THOUGHT I WAS UGLY"

She was just two and a half years old when she had come home from playschool and put her hand next to her mother's and pronounced: "Kikka (Snigdha's pet name) kaali, mama gori"—I'm black, mamma is fair. "My mother was heartbroken," she recalls, "and went to the nursery that very day to ask what was said in school." For Snigdha, the episode demonstrates how discrimination against dark skin begins early, even before a child can string a sentence together.

In school, she'd be called "*kaali saand*" (black bull), and in Class 10 she would find herself kicked out of the dance group because her complexion did not suit the composition of the rest of the group. "That's when it struck me hard, that may be I'm ugly," recounts Snigdha. By the time Covid-19 kicked in, holed up at home, her insecurities peaked to a degree that she began seeking brightening products to "fix" herself. The experience compelled her to shoot a short titled 'You', documenting the melancholia of a young insecure woman.

Now a part of the film industry, Snigdha says it's routine to see "fair-skinned" as a requisite for female parts in casting calls. But she has now evolved enough to realise that her skin tone is not something that needs "acceptance". "It's not a deformity, it's normal."

–Suhani Singh